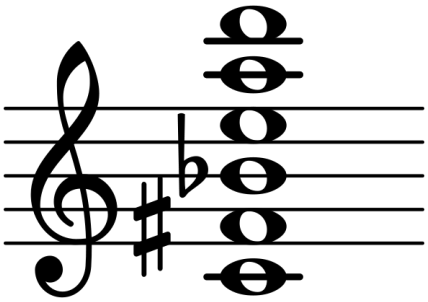


THE ULTIMATE GUIDE TO COOL CHORDS

BY JAZZ LAB



By Henrique Eisenmann, DMA.

HARMONY is EVERYTHING

Harmony is one the most essential elements when developing your personal artistic voice. Every great artist in history, from J.S. Bach to Jacob Collier, created their own way to understand and express harmonies. This guide was written with the goal of offering you some tools to research and develop YOUR harmonic voice, and boost your harmonic vocabulary so that in your next gig you will sound completely unique!

> *You don't get Harmony when everybody sings the same note*
>
> -Doug Floyd

"It all started when I was 15 years old. Instead of asking for autographs after concerts, I started asking musicians for their favorite chord, handing them my small music notebook. After a couple of years, I started collecting more and more chords from all the jazz masters, and that small notebook became a real treasure of amazing chords... "

THE ENCYCLOPEDIA OF CHORDS



The best way to start is to create your own encyclopedia of chords, in which you write down all the great chords that you discover/listen/learn.

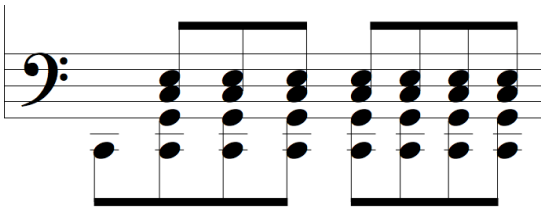
Here's a simple way to start: let's write down the multiple different ways that different composers decided to play a C major chord (regardless of your instrument, you can try to play them):



J.S. BACH



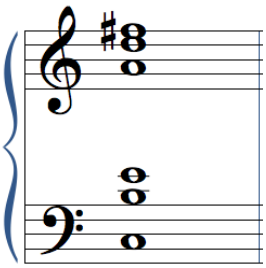
W.A. MOZART



L. van BEETHOVEN



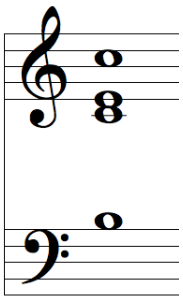
F. CHOPIN



Chick Corea



Brad Mehldau



Bill Evans

All of the above pianists composers were playing a C major, and still each of them used a completely unique voicing. Some composers like Mozart kept it really simple, but used rhythm to make it interesting. Others such as Chick Corea added tensions (maj7, 9th, 6th, #11) to change the color; others such as Bill Evans chose to use just one tension (maj7) but organize the notes in a very unusual place (in this case, using the maj7 in the bottom of the chord).

PRACTICE TIP: Do some research on transcriptions on Youtube or Google, and find some interesting voicings for major chords. Transpose them to C major so it's easier to analyze. Try playing tunes and standards replacing all major chords by your chosen voicing.



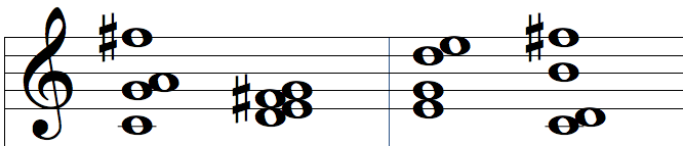
MODAL APPROACH

One great way to create new and unique chords is to think of each chord as a mode. This approach was deeply studied by George Russell in his epic Lydian Chromatic Concept of Tonal Organization book. Basically, instead of thinking about chords based on 3rds, containing the root, 3rd, 5th and tensions, this approach encourages you to look at the mode where that chord is coming from, and choose different combinations of notes from that mode, even if the most basic notes are missing. For example, let's take our C major chord. The basic mode suggested for major chords is the Lydian mode (although the Ionian is back to fashion, and it sounds pretty cool):



(C major Lydian)

Now, let's try to create some random combinations of 4-notes creating chords (don't think about the theory of it, just start randomly):

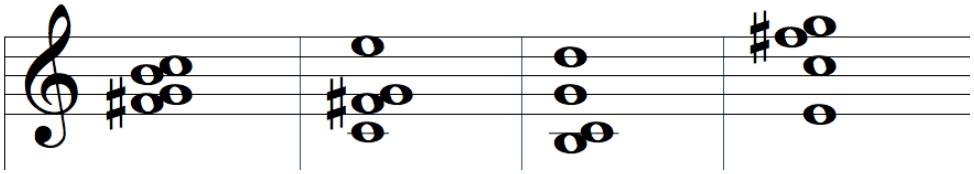


(creative C majors)

The notes for each of these chords were picked randomly from the Lydian mode. Notice that many times the root is missing, or the 3rd and 5th, but that doesn't matter. These chords sound more abstract and interesting. I avoided choosing notes that would resemble traditional chord shapes.

When creating these types of chords, I encourage you to search for minor 2nds intervals in the mode and try to incorporate them into your

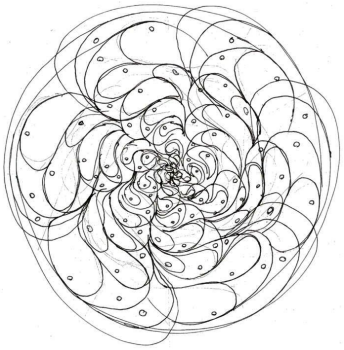
chords. In this case, C Lydian has two minor seconds (F#-G and B-C), here are some chords using these intervals:



(C major chords using minor seconds)

Practice Tip: Regardless of your instrument, try inventing your own chords using 4-note voicings, notate your favorite options. Try applying the same thought on different modes (Dorian, Phrygian, Diminished, Whole-Tone, etc...)

CONSTANT STRUCTURES



– – – – X

This is another great reharmonization exercise that may lead you to discover some pretty cool chords. It consists of choosing an initial voicing and modulating it up and down according to the melody. You can do this modally (Stravinsky used it all the time), or chromatically (Herbie Hancock loves this one). Here is an example of chromatic constant structures. I love using simple silly melodies for this one, such as Christmas songs. Here is the melody for Silent Night.



The next step is to choose any random chord/voicing that has a G on top (since G is the first note of the melody). I will choose a nice

augmented chord, and will modulate that chord according to the melody, ignoring the key I'm in:

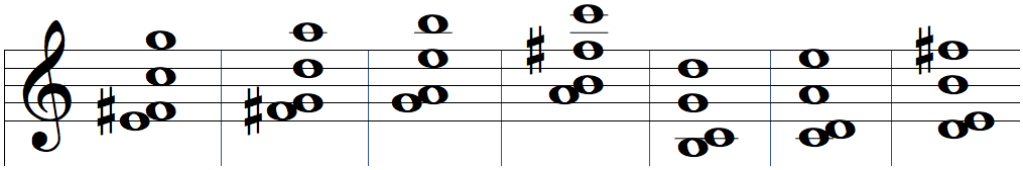


The result is very modern-sounding…. Notice that each chord is in a completely different key, however the top note is still preserved as the Silent Night Melody.

The same approach can be done Modally. In this case, we choose a starting voicing, but move it around inside a mode (respecting the accidentals), here is an example: Let's play Silent Night Using a C major Lydian with Constant Structures.

First I create my initial voicing:  (I like this one!)

Next, I play the entire Lydian mode using this chord with this exact intervallic structer, but respecting the accidentals:



(the top note on each chord is forming the Lydian Scale).

Next, we apply these chords to Silent night (I love the 7th bar!)



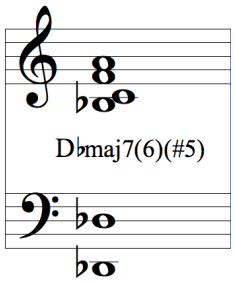
Of course, we are deeply changing the original tune, but the results are unique and fresh and original! This is a great tool for arranging or re-composing music.

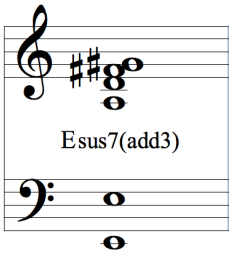
Practice Tip: Choose some silly melodies (Happy Birthday, Christmas songs, Mary had a Little Lamb) and apply some crazy Constant structures (modal and chromatic); see how far you can take this idea.

WE ASKED SOME OF OUR JAZZ LAB TEACHERS AND SPECIAL GUESTS FOR THEIR FAVORITE CHORDS (tonal or atonal), THIS IS THE RESULT:

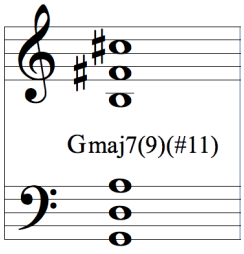
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MICHAEL MAYO:

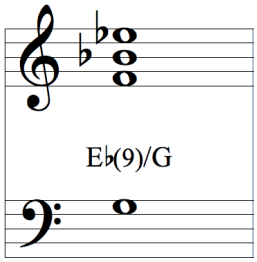




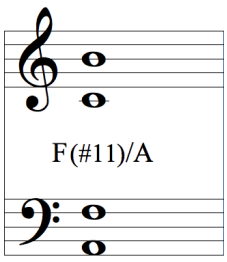
HENRIQUE EISENMANN



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CAIO AFIUNE



(Keep expanding your collection of amazing chords; ask your friends, teachers, favorite artists, instagram friends, etc…)